Telegram comment-section experiment: proposed setup

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2 November 2026 (draft for discussion)

Question

The observational paper finds pro-Russian coordinated comments inside Ukrainian comment sections and little evidence of durable persuasion. We propose an experiment that asks whether raising the volume of these comments changes what Ukrainians believe and what they think other Ukrainians believe, and whether language or AI authorship changes that effect. Coordinated comments in every arm push the Russian side.

A working preview of every arm and both questionnaires is here: https://hazemibr.com/telegram_experiment/. The coloured labels on the comments in the preview are for us and would not appear to participants.

Design

Participants are Ukrainians recruited through KIIS, both Russian and Ukrainian speakers. Each person stays in one arm and reads four stories in a Telegram-style feed, with comments always open, for at least 15 seconds per post. There are nine between-subject arms.

Arm	Ukrainian post	Russian post
Control: post only, no comments	yes	yes
Natural mix of real coordinated comments	yes	yes
Amplified volume, real coordinated comments	yes	yes
Amplified volume, real comments translated into Ukrainian	yes	not run
Amplified volume, AI-written comments	yes	yes

We omit the translated arm under Russian posts because Ukrainian comments in a Russian-language section rarely occur naturally. In the AI arms, a model writes a comment tailored to the post that advances the Russian side and chooses the language itself. AI comments would be generated once, reviewed and frozen, so that every participant in an arm sees the same material, and they would fill the coordinated slots only.

Stimuli

Each story appeared in both a Ukrainian-language and a Russian-language Ukrainian channel. The post text always comes from the Ukrainian-language channel, and the Russian version is its translation, which holds the wording constant. Organic comments come from the matching post in each language: under the Russian version they come from a Russian-language Ukrainian channel and not from Russia's ecosystem, so that language is what varies and not the overall comment climate. Each section shows 20 comments. Coordinated comments are real, on the same topic as the story, and appear once each; amplified arms borrow them from other posts on that topic. Display names are synthetic, and all posts appear under one invented neutral channel name.

We matched 76,764 Ukrainian-language posts and 12,835 Russian-language posts (September 2025 to February 2026, at least 25 comments), within 36 hours and by text similarity. This gave candidate matches for

42,184 Ukrainian-language posts, which means supply is not a constraint. We read the strongest pairs on three topics and propose 13 stories: four on energy, four on mobilisation and five on Western support. We removed coordinated and organic comments with ethnic slurs or hate speech. The translations were drafted with Claude and need checking by a native speaker.

Dose

We count pro-Russian coordinated comments among the first 20 comments of each section, the portion a reader sees, across sections with at least 20 comments. Among sections with at least one such comment, the counts are as follows.

Channel language	Sections with one or more	Median	90th percentile	99th percentile
Ukrainian	1,857 of 429,362	1	1	3
Russian	851 of 52,806	1	3	6

The natural arm shows 1 of 20 comments. The preview uses the 99th percentile for the amplified arms, which gives 3 of 20 under Ukrainian posts and 6 of 20 under Russian posts, because at the 90th percentile the Ukrainian amplified arm would equal the natural arm. These counts include only comments that matched a known claim and carry a pro-Russian stance label, without correction, and they therefore understate the real volume.

Outcomes

The primary outcomes, asked for each of the three topics, are personal agreement with a statement (0 to 10) and the percentage of Ukrainians believed to agree (0 to 100). Secondary outcomes are a feeling thermometer toward Russia, who is winning, the probability that Ukraine wins, the probability that European support continues, vote intention and favourability. Comment arms also estimate the share of comments that were coordinated or AI-written and flag suspect comments. The debrief states which kind of comments each participant saw, and the AI arms are told that an AI wrote those comments.

Decisions for us

1. Which of the 13 proposed stories to keep. A review sheet is available for Yurii and you.
2. Whether the amplified dose should be the 99th percentile, as in the preview.
3. Whether post language is matched to the participant's language or randomized within each language group. Randomizing roughly doubles the sample we need, and the choice depends on the KIIS price per respondent.
4. How to set the reaction counts shown under comments. The preview numbers are placeholders. Real counts would differ by arm, so I propose drawing all of them from one real distribution.
5. Which AI model and prompt to use. The AI comments in the preview are unreviewed drafts written with Claude for three stories, shown only to illustrate the arm.
6. Whether the three outcome statements, carried over from the earlier design, still fit the final stories.